Spider webs, then deeper

Spider Webs

Name _____ Date _____



Little Wonderer stopped on the path. "The bush is wearing lace," the little one whispered. Big Wonderer tipped its head. Overnight the web was almost invisible. Cool air left dew beads on the silk, and the beads caught the morning light. As the day warms, many drops shrink. Dew helps us see; it is not the spider's glue.



Many orb webs share three parts. The hub is the small center. Radii are the straight spokes. The capture spiral winds around them. On many webs the radii stay dry and strong, while the spiral holds tiny glue beads. Spiders often walk the dry lines. Not every spider builds an orb, so what you find outside may look different.



Spiders make more than one silk. Dragline silk is strong for bridges and safety lines. Capture silk is for catching. Some spiders coat the spiral with glue droplets. Others comb out a dry, woolly silk with a cribellum plate. That woolly silk can snag without sticky glue. Researchers still compare how each kind works in wind and rain.

orb	a roundish wheel-shaped web with spokes and a spiral
radii	the straight spoke lines that run from the hub outward
spiral	the winding line that circles the spokes
silk	the strong thread a spider makes from its body
cribellum	a tiny spinning plate that helps make woolly catch silk
vibration	a tiny shake that can travel along a line of silk

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Big Wonderer watched the hub. A spider rested with legs on the radii. Silk carries vibrations, so a tiny tug can travel to those legs. Sensors help tell a breeze from prey. The spider usually does not need every line to be sticky, because it knows the dry paths home.



Little Wonderer lifted a pencil. Big Wonderer stayed a step back. A web is a home and a trap. Touching can break hours of work and may put a spider or a child too close. Sketch from a safe distance. Use eyes, a notebook, or a camera zoom. Leave the silk where it is.



Morning dew is water from the air, not spider glue. The drops sit on silk and sparkle, so the spiral pattern pops into view. Later the air warms and many beads shrink or fall. If you miss the dew, a soft side light may still reveal dry radii. Keep looking with care.

1. Why can a web be hard to see at night, then easy at dawn?
2. Which parts of an orb web are often dry, and which may hold glue?
3. How can some silk catch prey without sticky glue?
4. How does a spider feel a tiny tug on the web?

Your turn

Write or dictate three sentences: one web part you noticed, one idea about sticky versus dry silk, and one safe way to look without touching.

Example: I saw a hub and long radii. The spiral may hold glue beads. I will sketch from a step back.